

Q What made you take this decision?

Any serious software development can only be sustained with a dedicated team, proper infrastructure, and marketing and other human resources, including a dedicated quality control team.

GNUKhata is one of those serious mission-critical programs that has to do with people's money. Such projects can't go a long way with part time developers, voluntary community contributions, etc.

Whatever this project has achieved so far is due to dedicated government funding from Kerala and some other bodies like the National Internet Exchange of India and the HRD Ministry of the Central government. As you know, such grants don't last forever and it is really a lot of work to get these in the first place. So, to sustain any project of the level of GNUKhata, there ought to be a business model that not just facilitates wider adoption but generates profits and provides an extremely good experience with total transparency.

Q What are the features that you are going to offer under the premium service?

Some important additions are GST returns without users doing any accounting entries, and the same with TDS, e-way bills, fully automatic bank reconciliations, and much more.

Note that many of these services are available from third party services for a fee. So, we will be integrating these APIs into our enterprise version. Many features are already available in GNUKhata for free, albeit with restrictions.

With the enterprise version of GNUKhata, we will be able to provide an end-to-end automated solution, which is very unique to India, and at a very, very low price range.

Q Since your software is under GPL, what are the advantages and disadvantages of this, from the business prospective?

Many products such as MySQL

database are under GPL and are still provided through a business model. GPL warrants a level of transparency and openness that can never be exploited by anyone who wishes to make the program proprietary. Any feature added to the software has to be under GPL.

The business model I chose to follow is to keep GNUKhata 'free as in freedom' and connected to an enterprise cloud offering that can put this product to best use.

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Q You mentioned that the commercial offering will be based on a 'freemium model'. Please elaborate on this.

As mentioned before, it's my passion to serve the technologically underserved sector. Micro businesses, small NGOs and individual practitioners neither have enough money to pay for enterprise software nor require any complex feature set. For such people, we would be providing a free hosted service without those high-end services.

GNUKhata is free to download and use offline. Our premium customers, however, will be able to avail our enterprise services, which they need and can also afford to pay for.

Q What business model do developers usually follow to make money from open source software?

There are several models, one of which I have already discussed earlier. Another model is to dual license the product, wherein a paid licence version

is provided alongside a free community edition — Red Hat and MySQL are the best examples of this model.

Customisation and support are another way of earning money from open source.

Q In your opinion, how can a developer maintain a balance between being open source and creating a viable business?

It's only a myth that software once open cannot become part of a business. This way of thinking has been further aggravated by several extremists who wish to impose their view that FOSS developers should never intend to do business and only work on a non-profit mode. As long as developers keep their code open and allow complete freedom there should be no need to worry about the consequences.

Q The GNUKhata team also intends to train rural and semi-urban youth in bookkeeping. When do you plan to start this and how will this be executed?

This will be started soon, perhaps in the winter of this year. The way to do it would be to train several like-minded FOSS enthusiasts, preferably with a basic commerce background. We would then collaborate with several NGOs to scale up this rural IT training. We wish to generate employment through this initiative.

Q You have built your business around open source. What would you suggest to other developers who are doing the same, or would want to do so?

Open source is now recognised as much beyond a simple social initiative or a technocrat's hobby. It is considered as the most preferred way of developing concepts and products. In fact, I would suggest all to be open source developers and consider open source as the master key to growing a business or their own career. **END** 